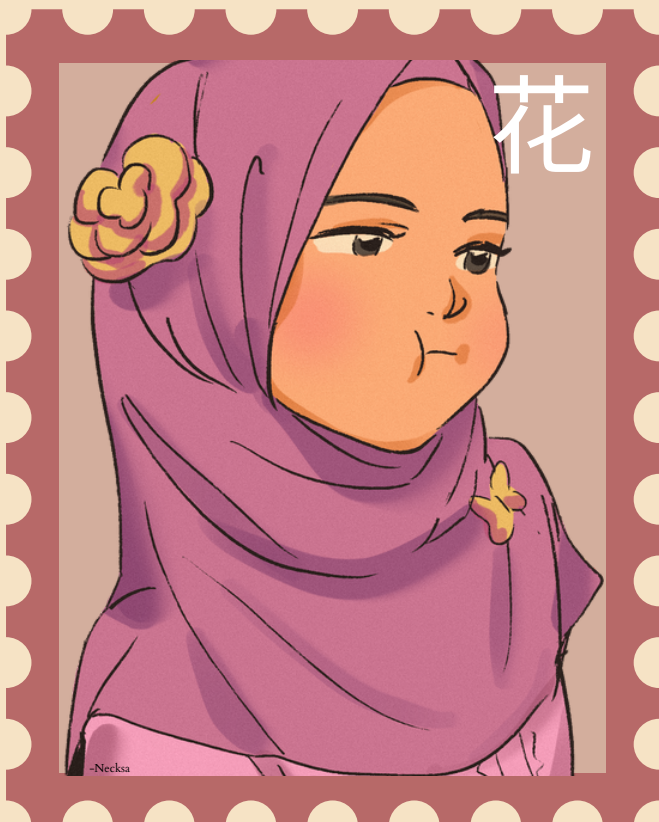




The Adventures
with
**HERMIT
HANA**

AKA my girlfriend.

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HANA**

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Introduction

前書き

Ma-e-gaki

You might not see the relation between the story of the book to the Japanese theme of it and I wouldn't expect you to. It's just that Hana really loves the Japanese aesthetics and I happen to know and understand design a little bit, so I thought of going with the theme. Before I go further, let's make a few points really clear. First, I am neither a writer nor someone who's read a lot of books. I used to be one of those few kids who would do anything but read a book. That probably will also explain why what I am about to write is neither content-heavy nor structured beautifully. These are just a few words for the girl I love and I know she loves reading, so I guess that's it. Secondly, and this is going to blow your mind. The girl I am talking about in this book loves to read! She is doing her Post-Graduate in English Literature. She is one of those people (or probably the only one) who can read legitimate novels before her exams in half a day. She is one of those people who would grow up to write wikipedia on Shakespeare. The ones who read books and enjoy it. The ones who love the different words that letters make when put together and find stories out of. The ones who say "The book is better than the movie" not because that's the trend but that's their personal experience and opinion. The ones who understand and manage to write a 20 mark answer out of a ten-lined poem. Yes, someone like her fell for someone like me. Love is blind huh? But I guess that got me interested in books. But I

always prefer to write than read, because she has probably read all the books that I have ever thought of reading and I would love for her to tell me the story,

The third point sort of justifies the name. I would love to talk more about it in the book and not here, but a little introduction wouldn't harm anyone. So here it goes:

Hana, 21 (when I am writing the book) has days when she does not feel the world around her like every other day. She sort of distances herself on such days and it gets difficult for me to reach her.

As much as I want to understand why it happens, I see that she still tries to talk to me as much as she can and I feel guilty for trying to push.

She however, loves to read on such days, or something that she would like to do on such days. That's why a book. So I can be with her, though I cannot. I know it seems really possessive but hey, it's my book. and no I am not possessive, I just love the smile she has when she sees the things I do for her, and how else to love someone if not by their love language?

Last but not the least, the fourth point. I don't exactly know if this is going to be a story or a random comic or a diary where I end up talking about the little details of my life with Hana, so if you readers think you know where it's going, you're probably wrong because I don't know myself. #neverletthemguessyournextmove

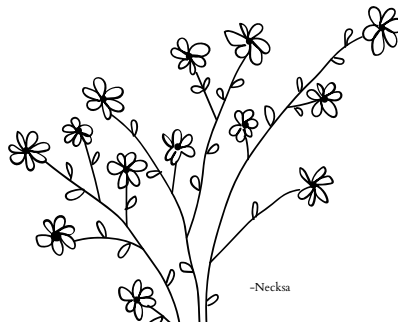
All I know is, this book is about Hana and the idea of that was intriguing enough for me to get going!

(God I hope this book is atleast long if not interesting)

花

Hana

I love how the meaning of her name in Japanese is "Flower". It sort of summarizes her as a whole.



The First Day

初 日

Sho-nichi

I don't hold the best memory from my past but I happen to remember the day I met her quite vividly. It was the 13th of February 2021, a few months after the first wave of covid surpassed and people started to come out of their homes after a really long time. 2020 as a year was not the best for me. It was my graduation year and we did not get a graduation ceremony due to the covid. I just closed my laptop one afternoon after a class and that was my last class. I wrote a few pages and submitted their soft-copies and that was the last time I wrote an exam. Most of the dramatic moments of a student's life are something I still dream to live. 2020 was also a year that went pretty hard on me emotionally as my family split into two and I had to watch my dad walk away. Though I shared my fair-share of hatred for that man, I knew whatever was happening was happening for good. 2020 was also the year when I lost my best-friend over a stupid fight. A fight I barely remember now. 2020 was also not kind to me dating wise; As my 4.5 year relationship broke in the most toxic way I could have imagined then. 2020 felt like the wave a surfer could not withstand. Felt like a winter which the swallow didn't migrate from.

2020 however prepared me for the longer goal, and if I could go back in time and change things, I doubt whether I would land on 2020 at all.

"Do you want to meet my friends? It might cheer you up!"

I agreed to Pragyaa without thinking much into it. Pragyaa very recently became very close to me. She and I never spoke much but knew about each other's whereabouts for quite some time. It was nice to have a friend like her around when I needed one. I soon grew to love and respect her like a big-sister that I never had, though she was significantly younger to me. She'd make sure that I have eaten something, would call up randomly to tell me about things that might interest me, and share me gossip that she knew would catch my attention. I was at my lowest and I am grateful that I had someone like her at that stage of my life.

"Sure" I said, I didn't mind meeting new people. Moreover, Pragyaa had really hyped her friends up to me and I was, if anything, a little nervous about how I would come off to them.

"Do they smoke?" I asked reluctantly, as I knew Pragyaa didn't.

"Oh yeah, bring a few ciggies. One of them does" she said without judging me for asking about it.

A part of me felt slightly relieved as I know smoking is something I could always fall back to, in case I was not having the best time. Plus, I don't mind smoking with someone that I know is a friend of my friend and it seemed like a good deal overall. I would be lying if I said that I looked forward to it, but it was not a plan I intended on bailing, last moment.

"Where are you?" I called Pragya on my way to 10th Downing Street, a Chain of British-style pubs offering global fare & cocktails, plus DJs & a range of theme nights. It's one of the few interesting places that Chennai has to offer when it comes to pubs and bars. The crowd here is usually good, and the food quite flavorsome. It is also one of the very few resto-bars in Chennai which lets you smoke.

"It will take us a couple more hours to start. We are waiting for V, and then we will have lunch and start" Pragya said, snapping back into the call after talking to her dear friend Hana. I could sense the excitement in her voice about the day that already had begun for her. It made me happy that someone was having a good day, yet chose to spend a part of it with me. I however realized that it's going to be quite a wait for me, as I was just 20 minutes away from the pub and she was yet to start.

"Cool, try to make it quick though, I am almost there" I said and she agreed. I soon made it to the pub and parked my bike outside. I looked at myself through the mirror of my bike and saw myself looking at myself with the intention to look presentable, which is an old friend of mine, to whom I had lost touch with for quite a while now. I walked around for a bit, and then came back to my bike and sat on it. I took the box of Marlboro Advance out of my pocket and took out a cigarette. I lit it with one of the lighters I found in my pocket and took the first puff.

"What am I doing here?" It's been so long since I had

gone out with someone other than my ex or my mom, that it felt weird and frankly made me a little uneasy.

"What if it's not worth it? What if I come off as a creep?"

There were a million questions generated in my head that ran down my spine, through the branches of every muscle connected to it, until I found myself having a full-fledged panic attack.

My phone lit up, and it was Pragyaa, sharing her live location as I had asked. She was about 30 minutes away.

Here's the interesting thing about overthinking. Time flies.

I took deep breaths as I knew I cannot be bailing out after this. I wiped off the sweat off of my forehead and did my hair. I looked around and I could see Pragyaa standing near the entrance. I smiled at her and she reciprocated as I walked towards her. And there you go. That's when I met Hana for the first time. I would be lying if I said it was love at first sight, but Oh dear lord she looked super cute with her little black dress and the wings of her eyeliner perfected to flawless. She had a lovely smile on her face accompanied by a black Bindi that she isn't supposed to wear. Her entire outfit felt really cute, or as she likes to call it *cutu*, or *kawaai*.

We walked in and Hana stayed quiet in the beginning. V and Pragyaa initiated conversations and Pragyaa really insisted I open up.

"That's what she said" I said about something that I don't remember but it apparently was quite funny. Pragyaa sighed while laughing and V appreciated me for the joke. Hana smiled as well. That's probably the first thing Hana had heard me say and do I regret it? Well, nah...

Hana did not step into the conversations much. She kept it to herself while also vividly enjoying herself with the girls. Neither did she seem interested talking to me about anything specific, nor did I find a need to do so.

A few drinks later, it was time to go and we went for a smoke. Surprisingly, all the four of us. As it turns out, Pragyaa does not mind people smoking around her anymore. I took out a cigarette for myself and offered one to Hana. (Which now I realize is the first conversation I have ever had with her) She took the cigarette and asked me to light it for her. Trust me when I say this, I was never prouder of anyone of my age group smoking as I was of her. Her smoking was so elegant and handsome. It was the right amount of balance between artsy and effortless. Her puffs so dense and warm. And her stamina was much better than mine. It was a pack of nineteen cigarettes and she wanted more after we were done. I did not know I had a thing for girls who smoke until I met her and now I knew I needed whoever my girl is to be a smoker. It was time to leave, and I offered to drop V back as she was not getting a ride back home.

Pragyaa and Hana stay close by so Hana would be leaving with Pragyaa.

I dropped V and rode back home.

"It was a day that felt new after a really long time. Maybe I made potential friends? They seemed to have not hated me, I mean V would not have agreed to have been dropped off by me if I had turned out to be a creep."

I had a million thoughts in my head while riding back home through the busiest streets of Chennai like every other day, but finally, not all of them were negative.

猫

Neko

Hana Loves cats and I love the way she loves them. I would be lying if I said that I was not jealous of cats,



Little Moments

ちよっとした瞬間

Chottoshita shunkan

“Themorte2” showed up under ‘people you might know’ on instagram along with a few others and V. I was done with my dinner and it was quite late. It was a few hours away from the first Valentine’s day that I had to spend alone after a really long time. My mom was aware of it and she did empathize with me, but there was not much she could do about it. After all my ex sure was one of the most difficult people both my mom and I have ever crossed paths with. I laid comfortably on my bed waiting for my friends to come online while softly brushing through Sushi’s fur who had a long day of barking and running around and was fast asleep on my lap. I sent V and Themorte2 a follow request. I figured Themorte2 was Hana as she and I had only Pragyaa in common and instagram algorithm is really wild when it comes to figuring out these things. Themorte2 accepted my follow request and requested to follow back.

You know how it always takes a little effort to talk to someone new? The fear of losing words mid-sentence, the awkwardness of not knowing your boundaries with the jokes that you might end up cracking, What if you make fun of something that they are really sensitive about? The need to find the right balance between being insensitive and over-sharing. The need to not come off weird yet different. Funny and edgy, but not creepy and sarcastic. Well, I had to keep none of these things in mind when I

started talking to Themorte2 AKA Hana. It was a smooth ride. An easy, fun and entertaining conversation about everything, yet nothing. Mind you, this is the very first conversation we were ever having. It was not an awkward “So what are your interests?” “What’s your favorite color?” It was rather a sense of not really having to introduce each other but just talk and share funny memes and instances of life. I guess the lack of an intent to know each other made us want to know each other. Neither of us tried to impress one another, yet both of us sure did leave a little bit of ourselves onto each other since that night.

We spoke till around 3 am; Way into the 14th of February, but I did not want to point it out. “So what are your plans for tomorrow? Or today” She asked, referring to Valentine’s Day and I had to admit that I had nothing in mind. She didn’t either, but she told me how she got reminded of it. “I just saw that my boyfriend dropped me a ‘Happy Valentine’s Day’ at Twelve”

Yes I know I should have mentioned it to you people earlier that she was dating someone already, but the story felt so smooth without having to mention that. She was dating this guy who is muslim as well and they were going through the rough patch. I did not want to be one of them vultures so I made sure to not come off as a guy who is hitting on her anytime soon.

The reason I mentioned the part about her then boyfriend being muslim is because she is, and I am not. As little as it matters to me, it might be quite a deal

breaker for her to even be friends and though I had known her for the shortest possible time, I liked seeing the connection I had already built with her that was not something I was ready to let go for the sake of religion. I know I count the chicks way before they hatch, but it was nice to look at myself being happy with the very presence of someone else in my phonebook. Let me be honest though, it was not just phone-book. It soon was whatsapp, discord, snapchat and every possible place. I bunked my classes so I could ride back home while talking to her, only to be standing outside my house for hours until she had to drop off the call. We spoke about movies and stars, love and laugh. About how strict her life is and about how Sushi is scared of other dogs. Did you know that Eden is an amazing songwriter? Well neither did I. Did you know how immense and interesting Greek mythology is? Well good for you, but I didn't. I learned so much about so many things while talking to her, while pretending to be knowing about them as well. How did I pull it off? Well, I actually found her interests interesting and learned whatever I could on everything that she spoke about or showed interest in. I realized that her interests were something that I never found and probably would never have, if not for her. I did not lead a life where I would just happen to stumble upon Eden's music or interesting clips and stories from Greek mythology. My youtube mostly had bengali songs and a few Hindi ones, and my book shelves were empty. I realized I liked everything she did and I wanted to

unveil the version of me that actually did what it finds interesting. Sure music was interesting, but I never tried to write a song before. Sure I liked writing small quotes here and there, but never took to understand literature before, or increase my vocabulary on the same. It was her, who got me to push myself on my productive side, to get myself somewhere with what I had.

So sure, I was counting the chickens before they hatched, but doing so got my mind to be productive and value the little things in life.

ツバメ鳥

Tsubame tori

It's despairing we can no longer hear swallows these days. I wonder where they are. I can however imagine Hana really loving the swallows sing. I don't know if I am right, but I am certain she did.



-Necksa

First Failed Date

最初の失敗日

Saisho no shippai-bi

I am not very sure how many days it was before we planned to meet, but I can assure you that the number of days did not match the connection I had with her. I learnt quite a lot about her. I learned that she had only sat on two-wheelers either with her grandpa or her dad. I learnt that she loves bike rides but unfortunately did not get to experience them much. Living in chennai, she has not visited the beach yet. She loves nature and she did not know that Chennai had a botanical garden. She loves anime and cats. She listens to the same songs on repeat and she lets songs and their lyrics get into her head. She has a strong friend-circle and cares for all her friends in very different ways. I also learnt that I was her first IRL friend whom she be-friended on discord as well, so it was really a step for her that she had to take.

It's always easy making plans with Hana as she gets really happy about the smallest of things, and the smile that she holds really makes everything wonderful and fair. I came to realize what was happening and I knew I was overthinking it, but sometimes it's nice to overthink some things as the overthought story feels really warm and enchanting.

“What’s making you all chippy today?” whispered Aiswarya during the human anatomy class.

“I don’t know what you are talking about, Aishu” I whispered back as I looked at her, with shiny eyes and a wide grin.

“Just tell me already” murmured Aishu, as her interest slowly started to rise but she wanted to act like she did not care about it.

My grin got wider as I said “So there’s this girl-”

Aishu chuckled and elbowed me. “I knew it! It had something to do with a girl, didn’t it? Is that who you were watching the movie with in the morning?”

The evening before:

“So where do you want to go on my bike though?” I asked Hana, who by now had said a million times about how painful her periods are and how difficult it gets for her to even get off the bed. “Let’s go to Sandy’s Chocolate Laboratory!” she said with all the excitement she could offer in spite of her cramps. “Are you sure you can go out tomorrow? You do sound real sick” I asked, really concerned not just about her but about the fact that I did not trust myself around her. She was way too important for me to lose her over me not ending up being presentable. I don’t mean to say that I was not excited to go meet her, it’s just that I knew I had to be on my best behavior.

“I am sure, but just letting you know, in case my grandpa gets to know that I am on my periods, I might not be allowed to come out” she said. I was not very sure how her grandpa would get to know about it, but I didn’t question it. I let it slide and agreed along. We hang up and go by doing our own things.

“Okay so, My grandpa came to know and I am not allowed to go outside tomorrow. I am so sorry” she texted at night. Meanwhile I had already had a proper plan to bunk my classes as well as get attendance for them, and I was not ready to go to college as it didn’t seem interesting anymore.

“It’s cool, we will do it some other time” I replied back. I didn’t know her situation enough to have pushed her on this, and soon my ‘not-very-positive’ thoughts kicked in.

Hey, You think she does not want to go with you? Maybe she just made the plan but you took it seriously and left her in a really awkward situation. Maybe she was just being nice. You do realize you read way into the lines till a point that it isn’t even true, right?

I did not want my thoughts to cloud me back into what I was and I tried to zoom out. I checked my phone and felt all the clouds fade away.

“Let’s watch a movie! I cannot watch at night as I know I will pass-out, but how about tomorrow early morning? Let’s watch a movie! You suggest, anything goes! Please?”

Sure it was a failed date where we did not meet, but I loved watching “The Sky Is Pink” with her. She surprisingly had not watched it before. I remember being real excited to make it to college extra early so I could sit

and watch the movie while staying on a voice call the entire time. She showed up exactly on the time we had decided upon. She hosted the show and she was equally excited to watch my recommendation.

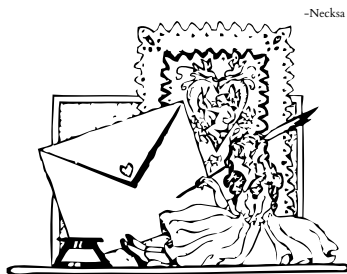
Is it weird to have the audio of the movie lower than her voice on call? I don't know, it probably was, but I knew I was happy spending time with someone who was helping me get rid of the clouds in my head, who helped me very unintentionally, untangle my spine from the claws of my own irrational thoughts.

“Yeah I was watching the movie with Hana! She is really cool!” I told Aishu. She smiled and turned back towards the face of the class as I drifted back to sleep.

手紙

Tegami

I love how Hana loves the gifts that I love making. One of such gifts are letters. I am not the best out there when it comes to writing but she brings meaning to my words and warmth to my letters.



The Day We Finally Met

やっと会えた日

Yatto aeta hi

By this time, I had begun to substantially confirm my senses and was preparing to give in to my feelings. Since February 13th, we haven't met, but we haven't parted ways either. Although our executions did not, our concepts did. Our palates didn't match, but our tastes did. And we were convinced of our love for one another's company. She didn't know when she became so predominant in my daily life, and neither did I know when I let my guard down for her. Speaking with her about religion and how people don't realize how similar all religions are was quite fascinating. How just one side of the story is known by those who oppose other religions. She was very open to whatever I had to say, and since I was there to learn from the English Literature undergraduate about various ideas, it was incredibly simple to talk to her.

“When are you returning from college?”

“I am starting now, what's up?”

“Do you want to meet somewhere? I can pull some strings”

I've never ridden my bike with such zeal before. She could not be picked up by me because she is only permitted to use Ola autos from her home. She couldn't smoke because she was having her period. Hana also mentioned that when she has cramps, she doesn't feel very confident. All of this came from a conversation we had at some point, and it stuck with

me.

How does she feel about meeting you? What is going on here? Damn, she really enjoys talking to you, so don't mess things up with her. You should keep her as whatever and whoever she chooses to be.

It was nice getting 'not-so-negative' feedback from myself for the first time.

"Do you accept requests?" I asked the receptionist at the Library cafe. I know Hana relishes coffee and reading. Where else could I have gone if not here? The Library Cafe is a really adorable and homey diner in Chennai that also has a really decent library. You can bring your own books or borrow theirs and enjoy them with a hot mug of coffee and potato chips. The ambience is also admirable, and it felt exactly right!

"Sure, you can share the Spotify link with us," said the pleasant receptionist with a warm smile. I returned her smile and shared her the playlist, that included all of the songs Hana had referenced, mixed in with some others so it didn't seem too evident.

Hana was having her period and mentioned how bad the Day1s are. If she trusts me on her rough days, I must meet her needs. I thought to myself as the receptionist added the playlist to her system.

"I'll be back with a girl," I said as my face went numb.

"Did I really just make it seem like she's my girlf-" nope.

I'm not even thinking about it. If I think about it, I won't notice when I start overthinking it and before I know it, I've messed everything up.

I walked out of the cafe, waiting for Hana, who arrived about five minutes later. She stepped out of the auto wearing a maroon hijab, a book with a cute little page mark near the middle, a delicate little bag, and a lovely pair of eyes with perfectly winged eyeliners. She looked at me and, based on the way her eyes narrowed, I believe she smiled. I couldn't see her face as it was hidden behind her covid mask. She came to a halt in front of me.

"Where is it?" she asked.

Since the cafe is not easily visible from the outside, I smiled and walked towards it, and she followed.

"So, how do you feel?"

"Ugh, I'm fine," she said as she walked up the stairs, "but the cramps could have been easier on me."

We walked into the cafe, and the receptionist smiled at me. She kept it subtle by not immediately changing the song.

"This place is lovely!" exclaimed Hana in the sweetest voice I'd ever heard.

"I know, it also has a cosy little library," I said, pointing to the door leading to the library. She let out a small gasp and dashed inside, leaving her bag on the nearest table she could find. I laughed at her enthusiasm and followed.

As have said, I am not a book person, and I had no idea what I was doing there. The space was far too small, and there were far too many books. There were books older than I was and comics that I had no idea were originally comics and not just cartoons. She pointed to various books and became ecstatic about their existence. Perhaps the idea of a place to keep a favourite book is appealing to readers as well. Probably something that connects them to a specific place. I'm not sure what it was, but whatever it was, it felt good to be the reason for her happiness.

We came out of the cafe a few minutes later, and sat down on the table that Hana had previously placed her bag on. We ordered coffee and cheese fries.

"I am lactose intolerant by the way, I am not sure if cheese was the best idea" she said making a funny face and smiling.

The cafe soon sang:

*Yeah, she's in love with the concept
As if we're all just how she imagined
'Cause we're in love but just don't know it yet
Well, tell me how I'm supposed to see the magic*

And she stopped mid-conversation to vibe to the music.

"I cannot believe people in Chennai listen to Eden! How did I never know about this place??" she said after the song ended.

I didn't have much to add and smiled along. I honestly

We spoke for hours that evening. Face to face for the first time. We spoke about mythology and space. We spoke about spirits and beliefs and stars and moons. There were a million questions that she answered without me having to ask and she gave me a million reasons to be jealous of her boyfriend. We stopped talking mid-way when she was having her cramps and all she wanted to do was roll into a ball, resting her soft face onto the table. I did not know what to do and sat there looking at her, really wishing that she would feel better soon.

Time flew pretty quickly that day and it was time for her to leave. I did offer her to be dropped but she couldn't have taken the ride due to the policies she had at her home and booked herself an auto. We stood on the road, talking a little more before she finally left.

I rode back home, holding a smile on my face that I knew was going to not turn out very well for me in the coming future, but whatever I felt, felt right.

コーヒー

Kōhī

I am not sure if it is the placebo effect or coffee actually keeps Hana up the whole night.



Stand-out Portrait From That Day

肖像画

Shōzō-ga



Oh we did take quite a few photos on that day as well.

Her Other Friends

彼女の他の友達

Kanojo no ta no tomodachi

Just like every other person out there in this world, Hana too had a lot of friends that she held dear to her. It was the time of Ramadan and she had to stay up all night as that was when she had her meals along with her family. This obviously pushed her daily routine significantly and she started her day in the afternoon.

It was all nice in the beginning as we started watching movies at night. Something she could not usually do as she would fall asleep. Now however, she had to stay up and I loved being her company for that. We watched Veer-Zara. A movie about an Indian pilot who falls in love with a Pakistani girl and it's a really great movie to be watching with someone you are potentially falling in love with. We laughed about how the songs in the movies weren't the best Lata Mangeshkar could have done and we shared our opinions on the movie plot mid-movie!

Things were good and it really was too good to be true. As time passed, I could witness the depreciation of the value of my time, and I could see her drift apart.

Calls were no longer answered, and messages were left at "seen". I do remember going out of my ways to get validation whereas Hana was way more invested in her then boyfriend and all her friends that revolved around him.

There were days when I checked my phone for every

notification around the clock to make sure I didn't miss anything from her. Plans were made but then canceled, things went unspoken, and before I knew it, I was the guy she knew she had in the backseat of her car, while she had the passenger seat always filled with someone else. And here's the thing with me. I needed validation from my friends much more than I need now. I would cut people off by taking a very toxic route in case I felt like they were going to do the same with me.

The clouds in my head started to return and the grip of the claws on my spine got stronger. I saw myself drift back into the nothing-ness of the vacuum that piled up within myself. The jaw of the falcon that rested on my spine slowly started to spread its wings and open its claws deep down my skin. Colors started to fade away from things that seemed colorful and the cries of the falcon were to be heard once again.

The falcon's wings were wide and covered the whole of my shadow that casted itself onto the wall behind me. I gasped and felt numb at the same time as my palms clenched and my limbs numbed out.

I realize now, that it was never about how she made me feel and always about how I chose to feel about a very neutral situation. I was convinced from the very beginning that Hana did not necessarily enjoy my company and I was just there for when she needed company but did not have anyone to be spending the time with. I never gave her the benefit of doubt that not

just her, but everyone deserves to some extent. Its however not something that I can go back in time and convince myself to understand yet, as I still have moments when I do not feel as validated as I justify myself to be feeling. It is however important to understand that Hana's ways of validation are way more subtle than my ways to perceive them. I would not be honest if I said that I have chosen to unsee some of the validations that she had passed towards me just because I felt like they did not stand up to my standards of what validation needs to be.

It's good that I can talk to her about it now and hopefully soon reach a common ground on it; However back then, Hana was one of the many friends that she thought I had and I clearly was just one of them for her and these were not the conversations I could have had back then. Sure I tried to get my mind syphoned off of her by listening to music or playing games, but the silence between the songs and the few minutes of loading of a game were heavy moments which were challenging to deal with.

A little about a few of her friends that I could keep a track of: So there's her then boyfriend Raya: Raya was mentioned as Ray to me. Quite a cool name in my opinion. The first I heard about him was on the 13th of February as the guy Hana is dating and the guy who is not letting Hana break up. It was a long distance relationship and Raya seemed to have tilted more

towards being possessive than letting Hana free. I did not see why Hana should not have been let free, as every action of hers was justified and never did she take any step that could be held against her. She always was and *Masha-Allah* still is one of the most loyal beings that I have ever come across. I understand if there were some things that Rayaana could not wrap his head around that Hana was not aware of, but those things were not reinforced with actual reasonings or explanations. I was really envious of Rayaana as I knew I'd be treating Hana as a queen that she deserves to be treated as.

Hana was not allowed to smoke, go out with her friends or look at other men. She used to stay on calls with Rayaana for the whole time she was out with her girlfriends or me. Hana was not allowed to go out without an Abaya and Rayaana did not like it if there were other men looking at her.

Sure, Hana might not be the most loyal person according to Rayaana, but how much can you stop one from just being free? Hana dated Rayaana primarily because her romantic relationship is the cushion that she chooses to fall back on, at the end of the day. To her, it is the pillow that she can lie on and cry about all the things that had happened throughout the day. It was hence quite a deal-breaker to her when she realized that she needed a cushion beyond the person that she primarily considered as hers. It was quite difficult for poor Hana to accept the fact that she was being judged and controlled by the one

being that she went to, to feel free. To feel natural.
To feel her very own self.

Addy: Just for context, Addy is a really good friend of her. Though they had dated for a couple of days in the past, they both had come to a conclusion that they were better off as friends than anything beyond that. Addy is one of those friends that her boyfriend can count on, to take care of hi girl in his absence.

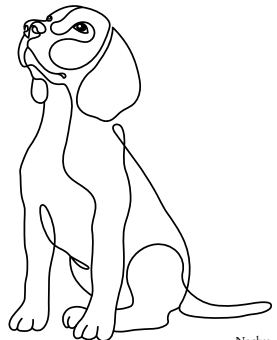
There were many other miscellaneous people that you readers might/ might not get to know as they did not seem to have played vital roles in her life or in this story.

It is important to know that these are only her online friends whom she met through discord. I was her only in-real friend whom she cared to add on discord as well, and I hold that position really dear to my heart.

犬

Inu

Hana has very recently started loving dogs. I would not want to go into details about how but lets just say I had something to do with it.



-Necksa

My Other Friends

私の他の友達

Watashi no ta no tomodachi

I was friends with one of my other ‘not-so-toxic’ exes who was also my college friend. She soon came to know about Hana and shipped us like nobody ever had before that.

“You will probably treat her like you should have treated me. I don’t mean it in any negative way but let’s face it. You did not like me much. It felt like a good idea to the both of us but you never really took time to look into your feelings any further. However the way you describe Hana seems like a realistic love story that I can see you live through. Sure, there might have ever been a time in the multitudes of existences where you would have felt that way for me and there might be a Hana out there in one of those million existences who would want someone to feel that way for her.

Well, this is the equation you have got with you here, and it seems like a deal you should not let go off.” said Radhika, trying to have a straight face while looking at a very specific spot at the wall.

I nodded and said nothing.

My friend Prachi had seen me through all my relationships and according to all, they all followed a very specific pattern. According to her, I know to go out of my way but I very rarely do that and I do that at moments when it is too late to work.

“You know you have two ways to look at it. You can either try to scrutinize each and every small thing that you have ever said and done, compare it with everything that they have said and done for you, try to balance out on a common ground and come to a very technical conclusion,

Or you can just wait and you will know when the right one shows around. You will feel the weight of technicalities leave you behind and you will know to take the path that you will be needed to take.”

Prachi always says things that do not make sense when said, but only falls in place when I look into them sometime later.

You are looking into it way more than you should. At the end of the day, you need to acknowledge that you both stand really far apart; if not to each other, at least to the society. Sure she is open about different religions and ideas but what makes you think that she is open to it in a more personal sense? What makes you think that she will be ready to step into something that has failed more than succeeded? You cannot hold your own beliefs as a standard. Name one friend that she has apart from Pragyaa and V that is not muslim?

And even if that is not enough to convince you, look at yourself. Not every accusation held against you out of a three year long relationship can be false. Your flaws are immeasurable and how do you think anybody can find peace in spending time with a psychotic asshole such as yourself? You define your negative energy as a falcon and your

positivities only comes from people who honestly don't even think of you in a week as much as you do in a day. You are out of balance. You fear your own father and the best you have ever let yourself feel is in the arms of a woman who wanted to squeeze the little life in you that you ever had. Do you realize how pathetic you are? Are you really going to unsee all this and ask out a girl who barely knows you and talks to you just to be nice? Why do you want her to have things tougher than they already are? What makes you think you are any better than the guy she is dating? Why would you attempt to take away her chances to have a genuinely healthy and colorful relationship that she can potentially have if you do not throw your existence in the equation?

The falcon had spoken and I had nothing to hold against them. I agreed and continued to obey.

秋の葉

Aki no ha

Hana feels like the perfect Autumn leaf that catches your attention though there are a million on the ground. You don't wanna step on it but want to hold it with you throughout the rest of the season.



Hana's Break-Up

ハナの別れ

Hana no wakare

It was Hana's very first relationship, hence her very first break up. Rayaana and Hana had officially stopped dating. The reason I mention 'officially' is because I never really saw her as happy as she could be, with Rayaana. I am nobody to point fingers but a mere spectator, and I would not want to be one of those friends who has a say about your relationship, but this is what I could see. Hana was a cheerful soul and never saw her being herself around him or even while talking about him. She spoke about how much she respected him and how she wants to ease the break up onto him, but she and I both saw it ending eventually and that's not a great relationship to be a part of.

Looking back, I would always be envious to some extent towards Rayaana as he had gotten Hana without any past baggage. Hana was there to love and to be loved and that's the purity of the first relationship that I really love. Nobody has expectations or past traumas that would make a simple gesture come off negatively. There would not be filters and the art of learning to love one another is something I would always love painting. I admit that I have probably learnt a lot through my past failed connections and so has Hana, and I know that maybe our individual experiences are what keeping us sustaining through the storms and I could never be more glad about it than I am right now or I have ever been, but what if the cause of the storms are partially the

experiences that we are carrying along?

I can go on and on, to and fro about this topic and I don't think I would come to a conclusion except the fact that I wish I could be a better myself for Hana.

Hana obviously was not at her best, though she was dealing with it as well as one possible could. Hana obviously had her girlfriends to support her and they did a really good job at helping her out of it. The unity in any group of girls when it comes to criticizing a guy is quite interesting to read. Logic and technicalities are no longer primal in such situations and the way to make the victimized girl feel better is by criticizing the primal cause of it, in this case, Rayaana. I would be lying if I said that Rayaana treated Hana right, but I never understood such ways to reinforce mental stability. Another interesting aspect that I found really different between a group of guys and a group of girls is the way they perceive the other gender in such situations. A group of men (and I don't mean boys) try to talk through the incident and start weighing the emotional stability that their friend had to the practical huddles that they had to face and in most cases, the emotional support outweighed. Men then go out looking for someone who could portray similar emotional and mental backup that they had now set as a standard. Very often, men unintentionally end up comparing their partners with the partners that they have had in the past but very rarely are they comparing the physical or the sexual aspects. It's

usually the heavy and moist moments during every other day that are abstract yet understood and perceived by their minds as negative, that they need guidance from their partner. Such situations sure can be handled alone but the comfortable way out of such clouds are usually their respective love languages.

Women in my opinion have a different approach to it. Women find inner-peace and start appreciating the little goodness in their life. Their friends, family, the warmth of the sun on a cold winter morning, the fragrance of the rain, the blooming of a flower that they'd planted on their study table a few weeks back. Women start off their romantic journey by giving it their all and as time passes by and witness experiences, slowly start to value the little things and eventually themselves and start pouring their emotions onto their next relationship by adding filters. One mistake at a time. After a failed heterosexual relationship, women tend to hate the whole of men, while men look out for the woman that could possibly fill the shoes of the one that left him behind. I would not go all the way to say that this is the norm, but women tend to be more emotionally supportive towards their girlfriends than men towards their guys. Women are more understanding about the fact that some might need more time and assurance post break-up than the others, whereas every man has their own ways to deal with it (mostly toxic) and the victim (their friend) is probably dealing with it not in the most efficient way if they are not dealing with it the way they've suggested. Men

slowly move on and forget about it completely, leaving the victim to deal with it alone and the only way they end up dealing with it is by suppressing it till someone uncaps the bottle.

I am not saying there are no exceptions and there are ample cases with the genders reversed. I am not stating a fact here but just writing down what I learned from my very limited experience and analogy.

Hana's friends were quite supportive and openly biased towards her, which Hana liked. I neither had a place nor the rights to be saying anything to defend men when they had criticism to be thrown at the gender. I did not think I had to justify it either as a part of me believed that Hana probably had not perceived me as the 'other men' that were being questioned by her girls.

I did talk to Hana and tell her how she deserved men who would find beauty in her wings that were never let to spread and she told me how my words brought her peace and helped her sleep. I told her things that I wanted to hear after my breakup and she told me things that she's ever wanted to tell a man without running the fear of being judged.

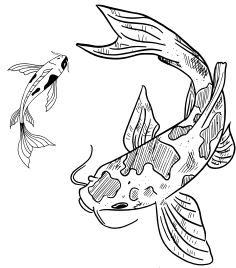
I would not be thanking Rayaan for the way he treated Hana, but he sure did keep the bars real low. I don't have much to offer now like I didn't at that time either. It's nice that she knows to love the little things in life, as

those are the only things I can probably ever provide her with.

鯉魚

Koi sakana

Hana and I went to a resto bar once where we saw a couple of koi fish in the pond. She looked happy and I knew we are getting a koi pond once we live together.



-Necksa

The Hermit Mode

仙人モード

Sen'nin mōdo

It took me quite a few deep breaths before I started writing this segment of the story. The Hermit Mode. To those who are like how I was and have to google about it, hermit is a person who chooses to live alone in solace apart from society. Hermit usually stands for people who do so primarily for religious reasons but that's not important to the context here. Please note, though it may seem similar to what the concept of introvert stands for, it is quite different. People who are introverted prefer to stay in solace over the company of other beings. It would not be wrong to even state that introverted people have one of their best times when left in solace and away from the presence of society or its effects. Hermit Hana on the other hand, did not really enjoy being in solace. It's not a mode that she necessarily wanted to have, but lately and found peace with it. Hermit Hana's schedule revolved around waking up, reading and going back to sleep in no specific order. Human interactions were a strict no and Neko was the only living being that Hana could allow around herself during those days. She would have herself wrapped up by her blanket forming a human burrito and would read novels in a day. Hermit Hana had always been a challenge to deal with for me, as there was no way I was allowed to reach her. No SOS, no emergencies, nothing. Considering by now she was a significant part of my day, it was tough to not have my calls answered or returned. Not

have my multiple texts replied to and memes not reacted to. Initially it was tough to just wrap around the concept but slowly I understood that it was not about me but about herself. What I was not able to accept was the very point that it had nothing to do with me, when I heard from Hana post-hermit mode. She did show her presence to her other friends and her girlfriends and as much as I want to believe that I did not fall in any of those categories, the falcon did not let me look at it practically and took the actions to shape a story out of them that spoke about how she didn't want to talk only to me.

Hana is not a person who would talk to you if she doesn't want to, but she is also not a person who would be rude with words to you even if she wants to. She is a kind person with opinions about people and I was convinced that she only spoke to me when she was at her best as she had to invest a lot of effort in order to have a conversation with me which she did not possess at the moment. My question to Hana had always been, "why do you have to put in such efforts only when it comes to me? Why do you have to be the best of yourself when it comes to me?" questions like these however are best unasked as answers to such questions are never taken practically and always perceived personally.

Hermitized Hana however opened up new paths for me. I knew I loved singing, but hermit Hana gave me my original lyrics to work with. I wanted to spend a little more time gaming and Hana's absence opened up a lot of free time that I could spend learning about games and

their stories.

Hana had always defined herself by the meaning of her name in my life, but the part that I didn't see coming was that she would not only be my happiness but also channelize me to happiness through aspects that I can attain without her presence. Hermit Hana was always tough to deal with and I would still stick by it, but Hermit Hana kept us far for long enough, only for me to fall in love with her in a whole new way all over again.

Hermit Hana obviously had quite an impact on my daily routine as well. My day included waking up to a phone with an empty notification bar, cold calling Hana multiple times while not really expecting her to pick up, writing songs that revolved around Hana and trying to look for the little orbs of XPs around my environment. My falcon however took a really different route on such days.

By now, the falcon and I were not on good terms as I took steps to ignore the wisdom of the falcon very evidently as I witnessed it watching. The falcon is only as strong as I let it be. The falcon can only feed on my fears that I acknowledge. The falcon however, was aware of all that I realized and it soon adapted to the situation. It stayed far apart, its claws shrunk and pierced into my skin no longer. It sat on my shoulder like a pirate's macaw and shared humors from my past.

During the hermit days however, the falcon would slowly stand up on my shoulder and turn back into its original self. The skin that only healed for a few weeks now, was clawed upon once again in the way that it always did. The skin when wounded – gaps filled by the claws did not bring any extra torture as it was the life that I had grown up with; However the re-clawing on the skin that just saw sunlight and had healthy healing therapy is what I was caught off-guard with.

I had found peace walking without the falcon's claws directing by crushing into my spine. I finally learned to face my fears with an idea of moving past it and not feed it directly to the falcon. I had finally found happiness with the presence of someone whom I did not have leach onto for the sweet nectar of glee.

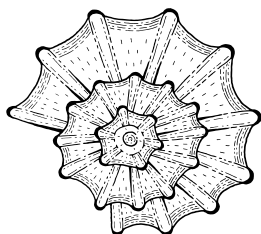
I temporarily lost all those that I had acquired from Hana when she was unreachable.

It sure was temporary though because we as humans tend to pick the positives along our journey sooner or later, and the hermit mode of Hana was not something that outweighed the *Hana* that she brought in my life.

貝殼

Kaigara

I remember taking Hana to the beach for her first time and she collected a lot of shells out of which she chose to give me one. I still have it back home right on my shelf.



Proposal

提案

Teian

“So whom do you like?” Pragyaa asked. She by now was a really strong pillar for me. She knew that Hana and I spoke and neither of us tried to keep it from her as well. However she was not given the idea about how I felt about Hana.

“Well, you know her...” I typed back. It's not like I didn't want Pragyaa to know about her. I obviously did. Pragyaa was a very strong reinforcement in that part of my life which was very delicately grown to the stage that it stood at that time. I however did not want Pragyaa to completely go against the whole idea of that as I already had my falcon talking me out of it and I had sort of convinced myself that it was the right thing to do. If nothing, at least I would not be one of those people in her life who looked at her not just as a friend but pretended to be a friend until it got a little too difficult and bombarded her with a proposal. I sure did want to take things slow.

“Oh My God! Who is it? I really need to know now. Wait, is it one of my girls?”

I could sense Pragyaa's excitement turn into concern towards the second half of her sentence. I also knew that it was way too late for me to back out and not tell her what was happening. Moreover, Pragyaa deserves to know about it; Both as a friend of mine, as well as a friend of Hana's.

“Well, it's not V” I said. It was the very first time I was confessing about it to anyone and I could feel my blood rush throughout my body. I could feel my temples moist

and my eyes fixated onto my mobile screen under Pragyaa's name, that turned from "online" to "typing" after a couple of seconds.

No, she did not take it well and told me that it was a very bad idea and there was no justification for it. I didn't expect her to be so negative towards the very idea of me dating someone she held close to her heart.

I warned you about it, remember? Why would anybody want you anywhere close to their loved ones? You do realize, Pragyaa is friends with your ex as well and she knows how that ended. She knows how capable you are of living and breathing toxicity. Look at Hana on the other side; The white nonpareil being with an aura of warmth and comfort. She is the very essence of what humans are meant to be. She is everything nice and positive. Why would you want to make things difficult for her?

Pragyaa eventually went to sleep and warned me to not go ahead with it. I obviously took it (not) very seriously.

Hana came online that night like every other night. I did tell Hana a few days back that I was falling in love with someone and she was ready to ship us like none before. I had told her how falling for that given person wasn't like falling at all. It was like walking into a house and suddenly knowing you're home. About how when the world comes to demise and the sweat and sorrows of

every man is merely a memory, about how the only sun we have ever believed in is getting warmer and the only planets we have ever known farther away; How the dawn might not be followed by a dusk one fine day, and yet I am in love with this poem of a person. This person has no bounds to shower themselves into the goblet of my emptiness and fill me with the finest of the wine that she happens to be. How she makes everything so lovable and alluring. How it is so tough for me to look into her eyes and not tell all that I have ever wanted to tell anyone but never found anyone filling into the hypothetical shoes of the princess that the prince in me has been looking for. Her words seem to take my soul out of my very materialistic self and wipe it clean, cleansing it off all the sorrows it had ever been a part of. How Prachi was right, and when I found this person, I knew all that I could do and all that is right in the world have their threads tied to my existence.

“Hana?”

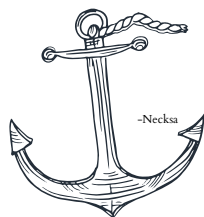
“Yeah?”

“ You do realize I have been talking about you all this while, right?”

アンカー

Anka

Hana wears an anchor as a locket which reminds her to always anchor back to reality and to remind her that she is the only anchor she will ever need. I love how she perceives things.



Post- Proposal

提案を投稿する

Teian o tōkō suru

I woke up late that afternoon, and I felt a little feverish. My mom and my grandma were diagnosed of Covid and though I should have locked myself up in a room with Sushi, it was not practical to let the folks take care of themselves, so I had to be the one stepping up, taking care of them. I could very slowly feel my palm warm up unusually and I knew I was Covid Positive as well. I knew I had to get enough supplies as one of the trips to the shop that I was making with gloves and mask might be the last for a few weeks now. I never realized how difficult it is to keep balance until I attempted to ride my bike with not the best health.

Hana woke up a little later and dropped me a few snaps that she probably sent everyone else on her snapchat. I sent a snap back. I did want to call her up, but I could not gather enough energy to do so. I was out of breath as I ran errands. Hana called eventually. She sounded like the perfect nightingale that she always did and it did not take her time to feel my restlessness and dryness in my voice.

“What is it?” she asked with the concern of the world,
 “I think I have covid. Just trying to make sure we have enough supplies before I fall sick. Don’t worry, I have my mask on”

No, we are not dating. If the story was this easy, it would

not have been worth writing a book. Hana neither agreed, nor denied the idea of us going out. If I think about it now, it probably made sense but I was not ready for it to make sense back then. I did not want to fall back into the darkness of the caves that I had finally guided myself out, following her enlightened aura. I did not want to give in to that very thought of her being just a stepping stone of my life that brings me experiences and lessons. What is the point of me learning to be as close to perfection as I can ever be, if it is not for the sake of being around someone as already perfect as Hana? I did not want to indulge myself into questioning things about the falcon or the angel, as I did not want to lose the pieces of her that I still had in order to get something that made sense only to me. I didn't necessarily believe that I would have my time, But I knew I had to learn to find peace in loving her only as much as I was allowed to.

"Just take care of yourself and the folks back home. You need anything, just give me a call and I will see what I can do." she said, and I nodded my head, which I don't think reached her but I am guessing it was understood.

After my chores were done or taken care of, I finally entered my room. I knew I was sick and I could feel the weight of my whole self run up into my head, making it heavier than it had ever gotten. I found my way to the bed and let the rest of myself lose as my head touched the pillow. Sushi jumped up on the bed following me.

Sushi sort of had an idea of what was happening through ways that I do not seem to understand. Evenings are usually the times Sushi wants to play and run around, but that day, all she did was sit right next to me, close enough to let me have my warmth from her. I took my phone out of my pocket that was connected to the earphones which I had on. “Come off on discord na?” I texted Hana with all the energy I had and hopped onto discord while listening to Anupam Roy.

Hana hopped on discord later that day, with all the energy of the world. It was surprising to me that she still hadn’t drifted off of my life. Is this one of those things that she does to make sure she is not hurting the other person when they are already having ‘not-the-best’ time and she’d wait it out being neutral until she finds the right moment to go ahead with what she has to say?

I would not want her to be painting a picture that she is not going to make a master-piece out of! She is an artist anyway, and I would hold our canvas close to my heart even if she chose to let it be incomplete. I would honestly choose that over her trying to play neutral and finishing the painting because she has to. The colors she chooses is not what she feels but the colors she thinks are to be selected. No, I would not be comfortable with that bit of her.

見る

Miru

Hana holds her mom's watch really close to her. She is really particular about matching her accessories but her mother's watch stays. It really makes me respect her a little more over new day.



Productive Mistake

生産的な間違い

Seisan-tekina machigai

As I had mentioned earlier, with every failed relationship comes learning, experiences and baggage that I at that point did not know how to deal with. It would not be true if I said that I know about it now, but the equation that Hana and I had back then is different from the one I have now and it is much easier to talk to her and to open up to her about how I feel about certain things than it was back in the day. Hana was just out of a relationship that in my opinion could have soiled out better than it did. The whole process of getting over the person as well as the idea of making a mistake of dating a person that turned out to be so wrong for you was something she was dealing with as well as one ever could. I did not realize that I had asked her out way before I should have. In my defense though, I was overflowing with my feelings towards her and I read a few signs that I am not sure were signs or mere coincidences. For example, I remember Hana telling me about a dream that had once, where she was at a wedding party which got disturbingly boring. There were people around her who hit on her and that was not something she was enjoying. She called me up and I showed up to the wedding a few minutes later and we went out for a ride.

I was not very sure how to take such things if not as a sign, but I now see that I only was a very good friend of hers that she could count.

My reason behind asking her out did not however just

revolve around me falling in love with her. It was the idea that she would finally be treated right. She would be mine and I think at some point the sense of ownership got into my head which made me react very differently to Hana. I got possessive towards her for the smallest things and it was not right of me to do so. In my head, I was just trying to save her from certain people but in doing so, I was not being any different from the ex she just chose to get rid of.

I snapped at her and I was rude to her. She was, however, really calm and mature towards me. She also went ahead and told me that she needed time, but my falcon and I were not ready to give her that.

One of my biggest flaws is to take everything personally. I tend to make everything that is happening around me about me. It is as if I am the initiator of the butterfly effect of everything that's ever happening. I tend to seek comfort in believing that I am the master of all and everything is a puppet show run by me, that got slightly overwhelming and the threads got tangled, thereby making me lose a little control over it all.

I remember ending every conversation by confessing my love towards her, which she did not reciprocate, but neither did she say no to it. However, the last time I ever did it, I was asked to not as she was not comfortable with it.

It did come off really difficult to deal with at that time, but it eventually made sense. I was being the one thing that I told her she did not deserve and the only way for her to trust me was to walk away from me.

It was neither Hana who walked away from me though, nor did I actively walk away.

We were just two very different lines on different sides of a mirror and no matter how close they get and no matter how much it feels like they have touched, there is still a mirror between them that made the existence of the both of us on the same plane even possible.

We slowly drifted apart. Neither did I try calling much after that, nor did she initiate conversations.

We eventually stopped sharing memes and she left my life as mysteriously as she had entered.

There was no way for me to have ever met her organically. Our lives were way too different. We had different routines, different set and types of people around us. We even grew up in households with a very distinct set of beliefs.

What's fascinating though, was that we were yet too similar even after all the different outer shells we had to wear. Our souls grooved to the similar set of beats and the set of the galaxy above me was the same as hers.

Maybe it was not the right time, maybe not this time, maybe not yet.

I don't understand everything about the concept of time, but if there happens to be a flow of time beyond this very moment and a trail of time left behind before this, I hope there is a time that witnesses the both of us together. Hana made me believe in things that I did not think were

as beautiful as they turned out to be. She told me about how it is nice to be nice. She taught me to smile with no intentions of getting something worth smiling in return. She showed me how simple life can be if I believed a little bit in myself. Maybe I can write a song, or write a book. I can do anything that I want to because she is the one who taught me to trust the inner me.

I could gradually see how a part of me had so positively changed by Hana and I knew I had to hold onto that part of me as that was all of her that I was left with.

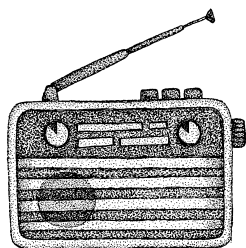
Until I have her again in anyway I ever can, this is all I have and I will hold onto myself with my dear life.

I thanked Hana and one fine day, unfollowed her.

無線

Musen

Though Hana and I have very distinct music taste, we also have a lot of them common and I love reliving old tunes with Hana.
Bade Achhe Lagte Hain



-Necksa

Solitude

孤独

Kodoku

A year later:

I work in Bangalore now. My career did not sky-rocket, but I am sure making more money than most of the people I studied with. I am no more a designer. I make designs out of my interest now and I realized that that's what I enjoy. I work as a marketing executive at one of the many start-ups at the start-up hub of the country. My work has me covered most of the days but with the freedom to take offs whenever necessary.

Since last year, I did not have the best of connections with Pragyaa and I figured I obviously wouldn't be coming off well when Hana would go and tell her girlfriends about how I ended up treating her. I knew that this was the time I needed to invest in myself. A couple of weeks if nothing. I slowly started changing my routine. It was comparatively easier as I worked from a small RK in Bangalore all by myself and my work was much less than the time frame of my working hours. I slowly started to push myself into isolation from society. My RK helped me achieve it. I had a balcony that faced the very few jungles that Bangalore has left to shave off. I woke up with the birds chirping and went to sleep hearing the clatter of rain with perfectly timed thunders.

I found peace in meditating. The very disassociation from the society excited me. It started off as something that I had always wanted to give a try at, until one day I reached the

very end of my thoughts. The place where the slideshow of my memories ran out. I could read through the branches of my neurons that could no longer produce thoughts to keep my mind from solitude. I could see the origin of the falcon. A little bird with its own aspirations and dreams. It was wrong of me to feed it with traumas. Holding a grudge against the falcon about things that had nothing to do with any of my actions was not the best thing to do.

Soon I reached the part of my mind that was never discovered. A part that felt feelings beyond love, lust, anger, depression, pain, guilt, or anything known to us mankind. I reached the part of my very own self that was not meant to be explored but to be lived in. It's a land where curiosity ends and answers initiate. The very existence of a super entity that lived deep within us. The very essence of power that we all crave for, is a power not worth wasting, trying to meddle with the very balance of nature.

I was the whole of me while being not myself at all.

I did visit Chennai once in a while. I had commitments towards my mom, grandma and Sushi that I couldn't turn away from. I also did meet Pragyaa once;

"Oh we don't get to talk to Hana much these days. She is in Saudi now. No idea what her plans are after this"

Her name did ring bells. Bells of reality. Her voice riverbed through my empty rented apartment every once in a while. It brought me a smile.

As much as I liked flying around in one of the million

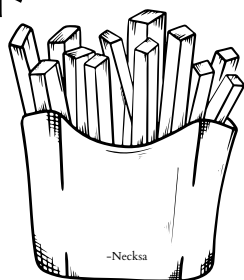
skies that I could reach, and though I really liked the wind of wisdom over my skin, It was nice to have her pull me a little back down to the earth. The memory of her voice that echoed through, acted as a thread to my kite, that kept me floating but at the same kept me grounded.

Songs were written for her. Poems, paintings, monologues, and whatnot. There was no way to know how she was and a part of me did not want to either. Hearing a little about her from Pragyaa had me motivated enough for a lifetime. She is too strong an entity anyway for anyone to be able to have her all for themselves. She is the very energy that the gods created and the giants built walls for. She is the very warmth you feel after you enter your home. The very smell of the rain mixed with the perfectly brewed coffee. The very sight of the sun falling under the only horizon one can ever see. The very melody of the swallows during the young dawns of spring. The very light of everything.

フライドポテト

Furaidopoteto

Hana technically should not eat frenchfries as they are potatoes and her body does not take it well. It is however cute to see her fight against it.



Home Sweet Home

家

Le

As things started to fall in place with Pragya, Themorte2 showed up on my “people you may know” list on instagram once again. I did not invest much thought in sending her a follow request and I soon forgot about it. Themorte2 did not accept it right away but did eventually.

I was visiting Chennai for Durga Pujo at that time. I had myself surrounded with my old friends that I very recently got on good terms with. They work now in companies that people have heard of. It's quite an experience to see yourselves and everyone around you grow up into adults.

Durga Pujo had always been special to me. Apart from the stereotype of it being an compulsion to be special to a bengali, it was also because this was the one time of the year that I would ask anything and everything to the almighty and it probably manifested itself within me so flawlessly that I would see it happen in the recent future. This Durga Pujo however was slightly different. I had been avoiding Durga Pujo for the last two years before this one as I felt like I was not treated right. I, in a way, held grudges against God and I had my own explanations backing my deed. This year however, I felt like I was being childish to hold it for this long. I went to the pujo only to realize that I would be amongst the very toxic people that I wanted to run away

from. It surprisingly did not bother me much but it was just the idea of her that bothered me a little.

I turned to talking. Not asking after all these years but talking out. Wanting things to be the way they are supposed to be. To make things easy and right for everyone.

Hana texted a few minutes later.
We hopped on a call a few hours later
She is surprisingly studying in Bangalore.

That was all I had to say and the story still continues. We started dating a few weeks later and I can finally confess my love to her and I get duly reciprocated.

Thank you Hana, for being the very protagonist of my story. Thank you for all that you have ever been and all that you have ever felt. I shall always be grateful.

With love,
Sohon

善逸

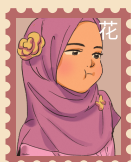
Zenitsu

Hana finds Zenitssu a "Cutu" and I find her "Cutu". So I am just going to stare at her as she stared at Zenitsu on the very last page.



"HOW THE DAWN MIGHT NOT BE FOLLOWED BY A DUSK ONE FINE DAY, AND YET I AM IN LOVE WITH THIS POEM OF A PERSON."

I would not call it a story but just a loosely tied experience of mine which I hold really close to my heart. I learnt more than I can ever pay for and this book is just a mere compensation for all of that I get from you.



The Adventures
with
**HERMIT
HANA**
AKA my girlfriend



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